



Cologne Cathedral

A medieval Gothic masterpiece that miraculously survived wartime bombing

In 1164, the archbishopric of the German city of Cologne acquired the purported remains of the Three Kings who, according to the Bible, had brought gifts to the infant Jesus. Enclosed in a golden reliquary made by German goldsmiths, these sacred relics attracted thousands of pilgrims to Cologne from all over Europe. In 1248, work began on building a vast new cathedral to house the reliquary and receive the influx of visiting worshippers.

Interrupted construction

Designed in the elegant High Gothic style then fashionable in Europe, the cathedral was a supremely ambitious building. By the end of the 15th century, it

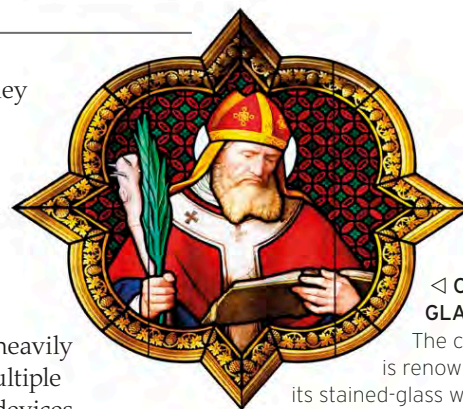
was still not completed, and both money and inspiration had run out. Work on the cathedral did not resume until 1842. The twin spires that are the building's crowning glory were finally completed in 1880: at 515 ft (157 m) high, they were then the tallest man-made structures in the world.

During World War II, Cologne was heavily bombed, and the cathedral suffered multiple hits by high-explosive and incendiary devices. Astonishingly, the building survived essentially intact, and restoration has since returned it to its original glory.



△ CATHEDRAL PORTALS

The three massive portals on the cathedral's west facade, copiously decorated with carvings and statues, are flanked by the towers of the two lofty spires.



◁ COLORFUL GLASS

The cathedral is renowned for its stained-glass windows, some dating as far back as the 14th century. This image represents St. Apollinaris of Ravenna.